We can also use a `_cat` (compact and aligned text API) API call to fetch the cluster's health. We can invoke this API directly in a browser rather than in Kibana, if needed. For example, invoking `GET localhost:9200/_cat/health` fetches the cluster's health by invoking the call on the server (localhost is where the Elasticsearch URL is running on the 9200 port).

When we start our first node (Node A), not all of the shards have been created for the index. This usually happens when the server is just starting up. Elasticsearch highlights this state of cluster as RED, indicating that the system is unhealthy (see figure 3.9).

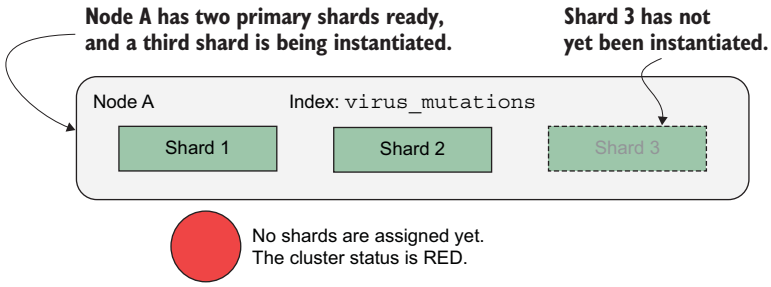


Figure 3.9 The engine is not ready and has a RED status because the shards are not yet fully instantiated.

Once Node A comes up, based on the settings, three shards are created on this node for the `virus_mutations` index (see figure 3.10). Node A joins a newly created single-node cluster by default. Indexing and searching operations can begin immediately, as all three shards are created successfully. No replicas have been created yet, however. Replicas, as you know, are data copies and used for backup. Creating them on the same node wouldn't be the right thing to do (if this node crashed, the replica would also be lost).

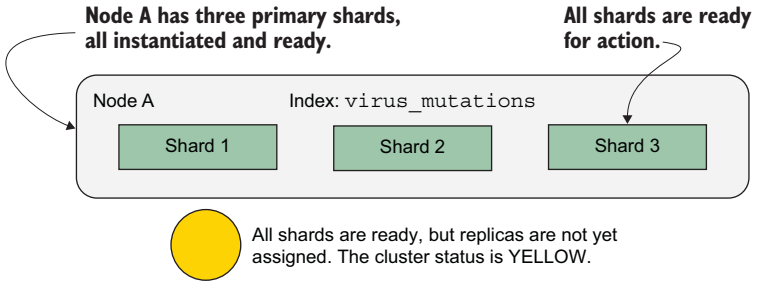


Figure 3.10 A single node with three shards joining a single-node cluster